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Faith Beyond Sight: Making Human Life Meaningful



Nadim's father was pacing anxiously. His mother sat nearby with a tearful expression. The reason for their worry was Nadim. One of his friends had told his father some things. Even though eleven days of Ramadan had passed, Nadim hadn't fasted a single day. Although he had eaten the pre-dawn meal (Sehri) with everyone at home, he would break his fast later. Mocking religious rules and practices had become an everyday routine in his hangouts with friends.

Nadim's father, although not praying the five daily prayers himself, never missed fasting or prayers during Ramadan. And he certainly attended the Friday prayer (Jummah). His mother, however, was a very devout woman. She couldn't even remember the last time she missed a prayer. But they had never imagined their son would turn out this way. Otherwise, Nadim was a very good boy. He has a reputation as a well-mannered young man in the neighborhood. He was currently a second-year student at Notre Dame College.

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Dr. Ahmed, a doctor in his forties, sat across from Nadim. There were no signs of his age or profession on his face. He sat somewhat awkwardly. Nadim's father had brought him along. He himself had tried to reason with his son several times in an attempt to change his mind, but it hadn't worked. Atheism or skepticism first takes away respect. Everyone except oneself is deemed outdated, obsolete, unscientific, bigoted, and devoid of logic. No one is spared from this arrogance.

Nadim was looking at this doctor with a kind of despair. How could someone who had studied science his whole life be so unscientific? His appearance and attire made him look like a mosque cleric. It seemed Nadim's father had started attending religious lessons at the mosque for the past few days of Ramadan, and that's where this doctor cleric had been discovered. Nadim prepared himself for the upcoming lecture. He had heard these lectures before and was ready again with his old weapons the weapons that had defeated his father and so many of his friends.

- "How are you, Nadim?" Dr. Ahmed began in a calm and composed voice.

- "I'm fine. And you?"

- "Alhamdulillah (Praise be to God), I'm fine."

Nadim had defeated many friends with this "Alhamdulillah (Praise be to God)." He briefly considered starting his argument from here but then thought better of it. It was wiser to wait for the next delivery.

- "Look, Nadim, at one time we didn't exist. God Almighty created us and sent us here. He didn't just send us; He also provided for our needs. He (God) is the one we

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must return to soon. The month of Ramadan comes only once a year. The Messenger of God, peace and blessings be upon him (Salallahu Alaihi Wa Sallam), has told us about the many virtues of this month."

Dr. Ahmed had come prepared, having learned everything from Nadim's father. His purpose in starting this way was to let the first cue come from the other side. It's easier to refute arguments than to present them.

Nadim sat up. A golden opportunity. A well-tested weapon. He launched it politely. "Uncle, please don't mind (if I ask something). Some questions have been bothering me for a few days. What is the proof that God exists?"

An old question, old ramblings. A counter question mixed with a gentle smile.

- "What proof do you have that God doesn't exist?"

- "That's what modern science says," a confident tone.

- "Look, the realm science has decided to deal with is the natural physical world. Science works as a tool to explain natural phenomena with natural causes— a physical interpretation of the physical world. This is called 'methodological naturalism', this is how science works. So, metaphysical or supernatural beings like the Creator or Soul are beyond the realm of science. Science can neither confirm nor nullify the existence of God. If someone claims so, he is no longer talking science — rather he is

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talking Scientism— another faith-based position." [1]

Dr. Ahmed continues, "The difference between theory of evolution (a theory of science having agruments) and Darwin-ism (a faith-based worldview) is another topic of discussion. For your understanding, Atheist scientists have written volumes of books against evolution, as well as many of the top pioneers of evolutionary biolgy are devout christians.[2]

And Mr. Hawking didn't say 'there is no God'. He said, 'We don't need a God anymore to explain the beginning phenomenon'— which doesn't prove that God doesn't exist. Besides these two arguments against the existence of God, do you have any other?"

Nadim nodded. Today's discussion seemed to be taking a different turn. Dr. Ahmed continued, "We don't have definitive proof for either of those claims. For us, proof means something perceptible to the senses. Imagination is not proof. Something that can be seen, heard, felt, smelled, or tasted proof comes from these five inputs. You can never establish with these five senses whether

[1] Dr Scott Todd, an award-winning scientist in Immunology and Oncology at Kansas State University, summarized materialist thinking: 'Most important, it should be made clear in the classroom that science, including evolution, has not disproved God's existence because it cannot be allowed to consider it (presumably). Even if all the data point to an intelligent designer, such a hypothesis is excluded from science because it is not naturalistic. Of course the scientist, as an individual, is free to embrace a reality that transcends naturalism.'

[Todd, S.C., correspondence to Nature 401(6752):423, 30 Sep 1999.]

[2] American botanist Asa Gray, British biologist Ronald Fisher, American geneticist and evolutionary biologist Theodosius Dobzhansky and many others were practicing Christians.

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God exists or not. God is beyond physical proof and three-dimensional universe and thus beyond the reach of science. So, to understand God, you need to apply senses beyond these five." Nadim's father came in with a tray of snacks: a mix of fried savory items, biscuits, and rice cakes.

- "What's that?"

- "Imagine you're flying in a helicopter. Suddenly, you see smoke rising from an island. What do you think is the reason for the smoke?"

- "The island is on fire..."

- "Exactly. You'll eliminate everything else from your mind except two possible reasons for the smoke: either a fire or a concert smoke machine. Your experience will do this.

Then your logic will eliminate the smoke machine, considering that no one would hold a concert on an uninhabited island. And finally, you'll conclude that there are people on this island. This is called deduction. You saw the smoke and you deduced the fire by discarding other possible options."

- "We, doctors, also diagnose the disease this way. A patient comes in and says, 'I've had a cough for two weeks and feel feverish at night.' That's almost enough to seem it's tuberculosis. To be 100% sure, to discard the differentials and to classify, we do a sputum test. Then the test reveals the bacteria. But even before seeing the bacteria, doctors make a decision based on the symptoms. Then they confirm their decision by induction and deduction."

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"This means that a special characteristic of the human brain is to choose an option and make a decision based on past experience and logic. We see smoke and conclude that someone is in danger there, even without seeing the person."

"Or consider this: you're driving a car, and the radio is on. Suddenly, a traffic update announces that two kilometers ahead on your route, rioters are vandalizing cars and advises you to turn around if possible. What would you do, Nadim? Would you turn the car around? But you haven't seen the vandalism with your own eyes, have you? Yey you'd made a decision without seeing it because you're human."[3]

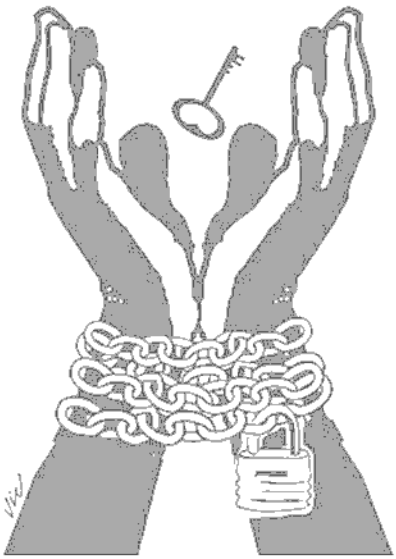
"Lower-level animals make decisions only after experiencing with the five senses. Humans, however, have the unique ability to perceive beyond what they see or hear. That's the significance of being human."

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[3] If the source of the news is authentic and the information provider is reliable, then we act on the news without seeing it. So, what's the problem with acting on the news of the afterlife? Now the question is whether Muhammad, peace and blessings be upon him (Salallahu Alaihi Wa Sallam), is a reliable source.
That would be a different story. But for now, let me just say this: the man who was 'Al-Amin' (the trustworthy, the honest) throughout his childhood and youth, who was renowned among his own people for his trustworthiness and truthfulness, did he suddenly start telling lies after coming down from the mountain? People lie out of need for money, power, or women. But this man? He even declared: 'Even if you bring me the moon and the sun, I must deliver this message.' What need did he have to lie? He rejected everything that a person might desire.
My question to you is: if the 'unschooled' man named Muhammad fabricated the Quran and Islam himself, then why did he do it? What was his need? If he was going to lie in the name of God, why didn't he start lying in his youth, a time for joy and pleasure, instead of starting to lie in his declining years? I want a clear answer. Peace and blessings be upon him (Salallahu Alaihi Wa Sallam).

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Slavery: Beauty of Divine Ordinance



Room 212 of the medical hostel. Six of them shared the room. David, Jerome, Abhi, Javie, Amin, and Kareem. The first four, despite the immense pressure of their studies, spent a lot of time clubbing and partying. On weekends, with loud music, they took the party scene far forward. Amin and Kareem, however, were thoroughly good-natured. Besides studying medicine, all Amin did was play FIFA. And Kareem was a real down-to-earth guy. Lately, he was seen more often at the mosque. He had also grown a proper beard and taken to wearing a cap; it suited his appearance. Amin, lately, had picked up a bit of agnostic tone. He probably doesn't have the guts to go fully atheist. However, he has learned to ask skeptical and doubtful questions.

It was evening. Kareem had just come back to the room after Maghrib prayers. Without looking up from the book he was reading, Amin asked,

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"Hey Kareem, I've got a question for you. You won't mind, will you?"

"Go ahead. Parents don't mind questions from their kids. Atheists are like children. Immature, not fully understanding and asking the same question over and over. I can tell what you're gonna ask from the way you're asking, dude."

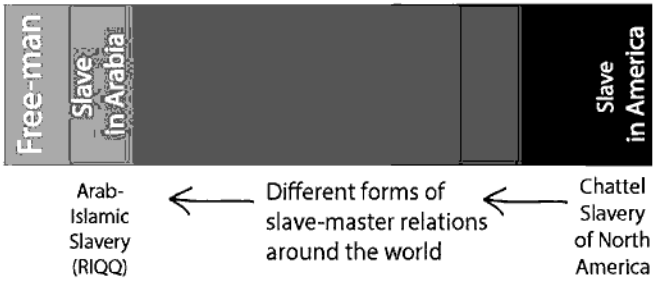
"Okay, dude," Amin said, really good at ignoring pinches, "Islam is supposed to be a religion of peace and goodness, right? Then how can it support something as inhumane as slavery, explain."

"You've got a bit of generalization problem there, buddy. The concept of slavery in Islam is far more different. You guys mix up Islamic slavery with the slavery of Europe and America.[6] When you hear the word 'slavery,' you immediately think of Alex Haley's 'Roots' and Harriet Stowe's 'Uncle Tom's Cabin.' Torture, whips, babies extorted and sold, punished to death. But there's a bit to understand

[6] British traveller Eldon Rutter, who perfomed Hajj in disguise, wrote: "I feel it may be necessary to add a reminder that **the word slavery has acquired a special meaning in our ears.** We have read Olmstead's Journey through the Sea-board Slave States, or perhaps even more terrible accounts of plantation life in the Southern States of North America, and we shudder at the very word slavery—because of the physical cruelty to which diose slaves were subjected. **This being so we really need a new word to describe the comparatively mild riqq or slavery of Arabia,** and another for its subject the 'abd or slave."
[Eldon Rutter (1933) Slavery in Arabia, Journal of The Royal Central Asian Society, 20:3, 315-332]

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about Islamic slavery.[7] Do you have some time, or what?"



"Go on then. Let's hear another one of your long-winded explanations," Amin said, closing his book dismissively.

"They are two completely opposite things. Our Prophet said: **'Your slaves are your brothers under your authority. Feed them what you eat, clothe them with what you wear. Don't burden them with work beyond their capacity. And help them if the work is beyond their capacity".**[8]

"Huh?"

"There's another Hadith (saying of the Prophet): **'Whoever slaps or beats their slave, the atonement for that is to set them free.'** [9]

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[7] Inspite of author's apathy, the contrast of Islamic slavery is evident:

"There is no doubt that slavery of the easy-going Muhammadan kind makes contented slaves. And that is precisely why I regard slavery of the easy-going Muhammadan kind as the worst of all forms of slavery. Let there be no contented slaves. A social system which rears men to be so ignorant and devoid of spirit that they are contented to be bondsmen…" [ibid]

[8] Bukhari, Hadith No. 30 & 2377.

[9] Muslim, Hadith No. 1657.

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"Once, a companion came to the prophet and asked, 'O Messenger of God (peace and blessings be upon him), how many times should I forgive my slave every day?' The answer came, **'Forgive seventy mistakes every day'.**[10] Want to hear more?"

"No, that's enough."

"Oh, 'that's enough' is it?" Kareem got up from his bed and sat on Amin's bed. "I am not done yet. First, let me clear the anti-Islamic junk from your skull."

He continues, "Even addressing them as 'my slave' is forbidden because it might hurt their feelings. When calling them, you should say 'my boy' or 'my helper'.[11] Once, Uthman (RA) gently pulled the ear of his slave. Then out of redemotion, he said, 'Come, pull my ear too.' 'No, master, I can't', replied the slave. 'Come on, I said (pull it).' 'Not so gently, harder. I cannot bear the punishment for this on the day of Judgment.' The slave replied, 'Master, I fear that day too.'[12]

"Oh my goodness!", Amin exclaimed.

"Listen to this too. A man was eating. His slave was standing nearby. Caliph Umar (RA) scolded him severely, 'Eat with your slaves.'

Another day, the governor, Salman Farsi (RA), was kneading dough. Someone asked, 'Hey, Governor! you're doing this?' He replied, 'I've sent the slaves to do other work. I don't want to burden them with too many tasks

[10] Bukhari, Hadith No. 2384.
[11] Tirmidhi, Hadith No. 1949
[12] https://islamqa.info/en/94840

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at once'.[13]

"Okay, Okay I got it. I got Islamic slavery."

"Alright. We'll see how well you understood, later. Now, imagine you go to war with a country. The fear of 'becoming slaves if we lose' is also a tactic to avoid war. [14]But let's say it couldn't be avoided. The war is over. What will you do with the prisoners of war?"

"Return them under an agreement."

"There's no one to make an agreement with. [15] You're the victor. The enemy is completely defeated. The ruler is also a prisoner. The vast territory is under your control. If you release 10,000 prisoners of war, they'll regroup and fight again. What will you do now?"

"Keep them imprisoned. What else can you do?"

"How long will you keep them imprisoned? I mean, how long will you feed them for free? This is where the

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[13] https://islamqa.info/en/94840
Shubahaat Hawl al-Islam by Muhammad Qutub; Talbees Mardood fi Qadaaya Khateerah by Shaykh Dr. SaaliHadith ibn Humayd, the Imam of the Haram in Makkah.

[14] Which acts as 'Deterrence'. Enslaving the captives in the Battle of Awtas was the last battle of the Prophet within Arabian peninsula. Next year was the 'Year of the delegates', all the arab tribes conveyed allegence to the Prophet (SAW) therefrom.

[15] After WW2, America itself changed the status 5 million German soldiers to Disarmed Enemy Forces (DEF) instead of Prisoners of War (PoW), so that the responsibility of feeding them wouldn't fall on the U.S. If they were declared PoWs, then the Geneva Convention would have to be followed— meaning they would need to be treated with the same facilities as U.S. soldiers. DEF means, they would be fed by the 'German authorities' (?). But after the end of WW2, who exactly were the German authorities? As a result, amidst extreme mismanagement, around 1 million German prisoners of war died due to a methodological genocide.
[James Bacque, The Other losses, p24]

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